Q22 Comprehension Check

Question: A colleague says: "Claude Code is an agent because it uses a frontier LLM that was trained on agentic tasks — the agent-ness is in the weights. If you swapped in a dumb rule-based policy, the whole thing would obviously stop being an agent." Identify the two claims, evaluate each, and state the correct layer-based description of what Claude Code is.

Answer: Claim 1 ("agent-ness is in the weights") is incorrect as stated. Agency is supplied by the loop design — model + loop + tools + memory + stopping criterion — not by the weights alone; the same weights behave as a chatbot, a workflow step, or an agent depending on the scaffold around them. Claim 2 (a rule-based policy would break the agent-ness) is also incorrect: the minimal-agent definition requires only that *something* map context to next actions inside a loop with tools and a stopping rule. The module's code demo shows a ∼30-line rule-based policy driving a genuine agentic loop (tool dispatch, error recovery, termination) and solving a task that the same policy without the loop cannot. The correct description: Claude Code is an **agentic harness** — a scaffold that manages tools, context, permissions, retries, and stopping — wrapped around an LLM that makes local, step-by-step decisions. The composite system is an agent; the artifact named "Claude Code" is the harness; the agency is in the loop design, not the weights.